

Umbilical cord carries blood to and from the baby



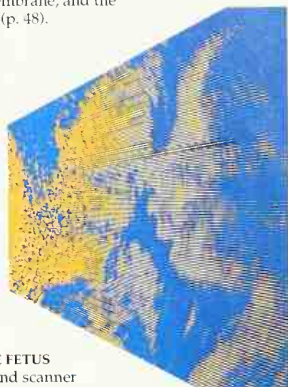
Amniotic membrane containing fluid to protect each baby

Expanded uterus presses on mother's abdominal organs

Each twin has its own umbilical cord and placenta

TWIN BABIES

Roughly one pregnancy in 90 results in two babies. Two-thirds of these are non-identical twins, who develop from separate eggs if the woman released two egg cells on ovulation and each egg was fertilized by its own sperm. Each twin has its own set of membranes that protect it, as in this model, and it also has its own placenta for nourishment. Identical twins develop from the same fertilized egg. They are always the same sex and share the same placenta, and amniotic membrane, and the same genes (p. 48).



SEEING THE FETUS

An ultrasound scanner beams very high-pitched but harmless sound waves into the body and detects their echoes. A computer analyzes the echoes and presents them as an image on a screen. Ultrasound scans of babies in the uterus are carried out routinely after about 12-14 weeks, to check all is well with the fetus. This scan shows the baby's face and shoulders on the right, looking to the left at its own placenta.

Stretched uterus wall

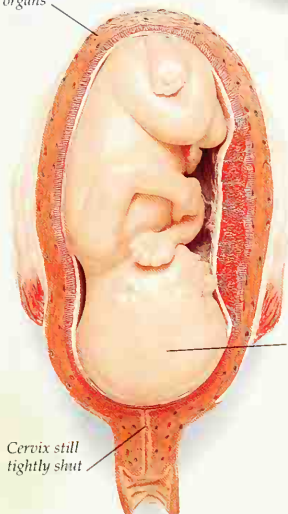
Placenta forms a link between the baby's blood and its mother's blood

Baby has turned upside down to birth position

The baby's organs have matured and are ready for life outside the mother

Baby has grown and fattened visibly since the third month

Amniotic membrane is the "bag of waters," containing amniotic fluid in which the baby floats



Cervix still tightly shut

4 SEVEN MONTHS
The baby is now about 16 in (40 cm) long and cramped inside the uterus. It tends to rest head down, the usual position for birth.

5 NINE MONTHS
In this 18th-century anatomical model, the baby is now fully developed and ready to be born. It weighs around 6.5-9 lb (3-4 kg) and is 20 in (50 cm) long.

